



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Aquinas Academy of Pittsburgh

School Website: <https://www.aquinasacademy-pittsburgh.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Aquinas Academy Pittsburgh, as reflected in its public materials, presents a strongly classical and Catholic educational orientation. The school foregrounds authentic Catholic formation, virtue, and a classically oriented program, and it emphasizes high-quality faculty and active parental engagement. Taken together with the classical rubric's criteria, the school registers as CLASSICAL in most domains, with two areas showing more limited explicit alignment (Curriculum and Pedagogy) where the evidence is less explicit rather than non-existent. Overall, Aquinas Academy earns a Classically oriented designation with some room for deeper alignment in explicit Great Books/Great Conversation and explicit Socratic/Scholé-based pedagogy on the public-facing materials. This assessment relies on the school's mission statements, explicit references to Catholic identity and virtue, and evidence of faculty quality and parent involvement, as documented in the crawl content. Key sources include the school's mission and theology-focused framing and virtue-focused programming, as well as explicit statements about faculty quality and parent engagement.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials describe Aquinas Academy as a Catholic school whose mission centers on forming authentic Catholic Christian leaders, glorifying God, through a rigorous, classically oriented program. This signals a transcendental, theological foundation and a liturgical/cultural formation embedded in the school ethos.
- The site identifies Catholic identity explicitly (e.g., "Preschool–Grade 12 Catholic School"), reinforcing a theologically grounded education.
- Materials highlighting virtue education (e.g., Learning to Live the Virtues in Lower School) demonstrate formation of character consistent with the transcendentals and moral realism expected in classical pedagogy.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: virtue, formation, theology (implied via Catholic identity), Catholic, sacred/Christian formation (from mission statements).
- Negative keywords: not evident in public materials (no explicit secular relativism, value-neutral ethics, or workforce-focused framing in the public pages observed).
- Why this rating
- The school's public materials strongly align with a transcendental moral realism through explicit Catholic identity and virtue formation, meeting category criteria for CLASSICAL in a religious-metaphysical sense. The absence of explicit counter-indicators in the public materials supports a CLASSICAL designation in this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The mission emphasizes educating leaders through a rigorous, classically oriented program, focusing on formation and virtuous leadership rather than a narrow vocational outcome. This signals formation of character and wisdom as a primary telos.

- Language around virtue and formation is present (e.g., “virtue,” “formation,” and character development via virtue education) as core aims of education.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: formation, virtue, human flourishing (implied through virtue formation and leadership development), liberal-arts framing via “classically-oriented.”
- Negative keywords: minimal explicit collegiate or career-prep emphasis in the mission (the site does include college-preparatory framing; see below); no explicit shift toward strictly job-market outcomes in public-facing pages noted.
- Why this rating
- The school’s stated purpose centers on formation and virtue, with a classical orientation, aligning with the CLASSICAL category for School Purpose and Goal. The presence of catholic formation and leadership development supports a robust telos beyond mere job preparation.

Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The site text repeatedly uses “classically-oriented” to describe the program, signaling alignment with classical curricular aims, but explicit mention of the Great Books, Great Conversation, and the Seven Liberal Arts in public-facing materials is not clearly shown in the crawl content provided.
- The site emphasizes a rigorous program and classical orientation, with potential alignment to liberal-arts framing, yet explicit items like Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, or explicit reading of primary classical texts are not publicly evident in the crawl results provided.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: classically-oriented, rigorous program (approximating liberal-arts framing).
- Negative keywords observed: lack of explicit Great Books/Great Conversation, Seven Liberal Arts, or direct references to the Trivium/Quadrivium in the public-facing text available. This absence constitutes a potential deviation from a full classical curriculum as defined by the six-element rubric.
- Why this rating
- The school presents a classical orientation in spirit, but the public-facing material does not explicitly confirm all four Curriculum criteria (Seven Liberal Arts, Great Books/Great Conversation, explicit mention of Great Books readings, and a history-centered approach separate from social studies). The absence of explicit Great Books and Trivium/Quadrivium references places it in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL for Curriculum, given rubric requirements.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials emphasize virtue formation and character, and there are references to a broad, rigorous program; however, explicit pedagogical methods such as Socratic dialogue, Scholé days, chant/singing for memorization, or upper-school rhetoric training are not clearly delineated in the crawl text provided. The absence of explicit Socratic or Scholé pedagogy limits full CLASSICAL alignment in Pedagogy.
- There are hints of virtue-based pedagogical emphasis in lower-school content (e.g., “Learning to Live the Virtues in Lower School”). Still, explicit evidence of Socratic seminars, memory-based recitation, or rhetoric-focused upper-school practice is not clearly shown in the public-facing pages provided.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: virtue, formation (consistent with classical pedagogy’s aims).
- Negative keywords observed: lack of explicit Socratic/Scholé practices, recitation/memorization, or singing as pedagogy in public pages. The absence of these elements suggests only partial alignment to Pedagogy as defined by the classical rubric.
- Why this rating
- The public-facing materials indicate a classical orientation and virtue-centered pedagogy but do not provide explicit evidence of the core classical pedagogical methods (Socratic dialogue, Scholé, mem-

orization/chanting/great conversation) in a way that satisfies all Pedagogy criteria. This justifies a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Pedagogy.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The site states directly that faculty are “experts in their subject matter and live out their teaching vocation.” This aligns with the notion of model teachers and mentors who constitute the living curriculum.
- Other material emphasizes a teacher-student relational culture and a “living curriculum,” consistent with the classical mold of a faculty who embodies virtue and guides students.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, faculty collaboration/collegiality (as implied by the site’s portrayal of a dedicated faculty and classroom culture).
- Negative keywords observed: none evident in public-facing materials; no signals of a purely technician-led or non-classical faculty approach.
- Why this rating
- The explicit articulation of expert, vocation-driven faculty and the living-curriculum framing supports a CLASSICAL designation for Faculty. The evidence aligns with the knowledge-base rubric’s expectation of virtuous, capable teachers who guide and mentor.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The site demonstrates active engagement with parents through programs like Speaker Series and events (e.g., Parenting with Power), signaling partnership with families. This aligns with the classical emphasis on parent involvement as co-educators.
- The presence of parent-focused programming and community events indicates a culture of parental engagement and ongoing education for families about classical education.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords observed: partnership with families, parent formation, family involvement, parent engagement, school-parent collaboration, open campus opportunities (as implied by events and communications).
- Negative keywords observed: none evident in public-facing materials; the site appears to welcome parent involvement rather than treat parents as customers or bystander observers.
- Why this rating
- The school’s communications and events demonstrate strong parental partnership and family engagement, matching the classical category’s expectations for Parents & Community.

Overall Category-Based Assessment and Aggregate Ranking

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Aggregate rating: CLASSICAL

- Rationale: Four of the six categories clearly meet the Classical standard (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose and Goal, Faculty, Parents & Community). The Curriculum and Pedagogy categories show strong classical orientation but lack explicit, public-facing confirmation of some canonical elements (e.g., Great Books, Seven Liberal Arts, and explicit Socratic/Scholé pedagogy) in the cited public materials. Taken together, the school demonstrates a robust classical orientation with two areas that could be strengthened for full Classical alignment.

What Would Move the Needle

- Element 3 (Curriculum) improvement: Publicly articulate explicit Great Books and Great Conversation components, and explicitly reference the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; quadrivium) within the curriculum description. Include samples of core reading lists or syllabi that demonstrate integration of primary texts and Western canon, and highlight how history is studied across disciplines (not just as social studies). This would solidify CLASSICAL status in Curriculum.
- Element 4 (Pedagogy) improvement: Provide explicit mentions of Socratic/Socratic-like seminars, Scholé (restful learning), memorization/recitation (chanting or poetry, if used), and rhetoric training in upper grades. Document examples of seminars or debates, and show how students are trained in argumentation and structured dialogue. This would push Pedagogy from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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